Fwd: Is exceptional academic success e.g. all grade 9's in GCSE subjects really mostly nature? Michaela Community School, in North London may prove otherwise

1 message

Tom Piccolo <tompiccolo50@gmail.com> 9 April 2025 at 17:00
To: athanki5670@gmail.com

---------- Forwarded message ---------
From: **Tom Piccolo** <tompiccolo50@gmail.com>
Date: Mon, 10 Jun 2024 at 10:12
Subject: Re: Is exceptional academic success e.g. all grade 9's in GCSE subjects really mostly nature? Michaela Community School, in North London may prove otherwise
To: nicholas.shakeshaft@kcl.ac.uk <nicholas.shakeshaft@kcl.ac.uk>

Hello

Would love to hear your thoughts when you are free

Thanks

Tom

On Sun, 9 Jun 2024 at 21:22, Tom Piccolo <tompiccolo50@gmail.com> wrote:

> Hello
>
> There is a large body of evidence concerning how academic excellence is due to a combination of nature and nurture, with nature- a large part of that nature being intelligence- being responsible for individual differences, explaining why one child walks away with all 9's and heads to Cambridge while another works in till supermarkets their whole life. This hypothesis

is subservient to the notion that we are not responsible for some eventualities in life, and that for some things- like academics- we have to give our best shot at, and leave the rest to factors beyond our control.

It implicates we should not beat ourselves up over academic failure, or ridicule others for working in supermarket tills and not being at a Russell Group university studying Medicine.

However, there is one school on North End Road, Wembley, that is completely, utterly flying in the face of our current scientific knowledge. Being a scientist myself (not by profession but by academic background- A*A*A in Triple Science A Levels), the results of this school have gripped me to my very core.

This school is called Michaela Community School, or simply Michaela. It is a **non selective free school** in Brent, one of the most deprived boroughs of London. See www.michaela.education for more or simply type in “Michaela school, Brent” into Google.

The school has an extremely strict, rigorous behaviour policy (which pupils are required to agree to before joining). This is the strictest in Britain- and actually according to many the world- and entails:

Being not even a minute late for lessons. Lateness equals detention- regardless of the reason. If you have a poor family background and have arguments at home and are therefore late to school- as many kids in Brent are, you get a detention.

Constantly fixating the teacher during lessons- if you lose fixation, you get an immediate detention

Constantly maintained eye contact with any teacher- failing to do so gets a reprimand as above

Lining up in straight lines by means of a whistle after lunch to go to lessons. Failure to do this gets a detention

Walking between lessons in complete silence and entering all rooms in silence and in single file

No “talking about what you want” during break or lunch. Students have to talk about a set topic. If they don’t- detention

Academic excellence is imposed upon all- regardless of differences in academic ability, you are punished if you cannot perform. Even SEN kids. That’s right.

Regardless of whether you have special educational needs, dyslexia, dyscalculia, learning difficulties, or anything else, teachers hold you to the same extremely high expectations. High expectations meaning all grade 7 and 8’s at GCSE.

The kids are **drilled in lessons.** Top set kids receive the same standard of work as bottom set kids. Bottom set kids do not have it easy- they get the same work as top set- and are required to complete it, correctly, and to a high pace, all at the same pace. Kids in bottom set Maths practise as hard Maths, all day, every day, till they can do anything. They are made to.

There is no differentiation. There is no “you have a lower ability than student Y- so we’ll make it easier”.

The school, supposedly as a result of **just this alone-** gets results. And boy does it get results.

Last year’s GCSE results saw a staggering **47 percent of all GCSE Maths grades at grade 9. Over 60% of all grades were at grade 8 or above. No one fails. 4 in 10 results at GCSE, overall, were at grade 9. 75% were at grades 7-9.**

Immigrant students who cannot speak English as their first language- get on average 8 grade 8’s at GCSE!

The GCSE grading system was overhauled back in 2016 for a reason.

The government made the Grade 9 to pick out those exceptionally talented students at the top of the country. Michaela implies anyone can get a 9 with enough practice. Anyone can become talented. Talent is not innate. Talent can be gained by anyone. In fact, talent may not exist at all. Anyone can exhibit “genius level academic ability”. There are studies by

Northumbria University in partnership that have shown, indeed, that talent **exists and is real and that for academic domains like Maths, hard work and focused practise is not enough to attain mastery.**

And this school gets these results year on year, for cohorts of over a hundred pupils.

The school claims that it gets these results solely by putting these deprived, low SES kids in a good environment. Lots of people online praise the school for working miracles.

However, research has shown it is actually the students- and their characteristics, that fuel the results of the best schools in the world.

High performing students select themselves into high performing places, according to research. The school's results were not always this outstanding- in 2019, it's first ever GCSE cohort got, on average, a mix of grade 6 and 7's at GCSE- whilst still miles away from it's current performance- it's performance that years would put it on par with Singapore, one of the best education systems in the world (albeit a large chunk of that being driven by selective migration of immigrants)

The school implies those people working night jobs in the local Sainsbury's should blame themselves- and beat themselves up- over their academic failure. They should curse themselves for "not trying" and "not working hard enough" even though many of them will have worked very hard at school only to gain mediocre results.

The kids at Oxbridge "only worked hard" to get there. No talent.

The school gives a message of vindication to the average person in England, Europe, the US, and pretty much any average person in any developed or reasonably developed nation where educational opportunity exists. MIchaela chastises the masses who "did not give school their all" and instead got mediocre grades and mediocre jobs- and mediocre lives.

The school enforces self-responsibility- it puts it as a weight on your shoulder- crushing you down.

You are responsible for your success- or your failure- at school.

Michaela implies we should curse ourselves day in, day out, for not getting the grades of those who end up at Harvard, MIT, Oxford or Cambridge. That “hard work” and focused practice are all that separates the masses and those “bright kids”- who end up at the world’s best universities- but who according to Michaela aren’t even bright- just damn hard working.

Just engrossed in focused intense practice and hard work.

Michaela sings the hymn that all children are equally capable. It enforces that ability is a made up concept, driven by politics to separate and identify human capital.

So- what are your thoughts? Would love to hear them whenever you can reply.

Regards

Tom